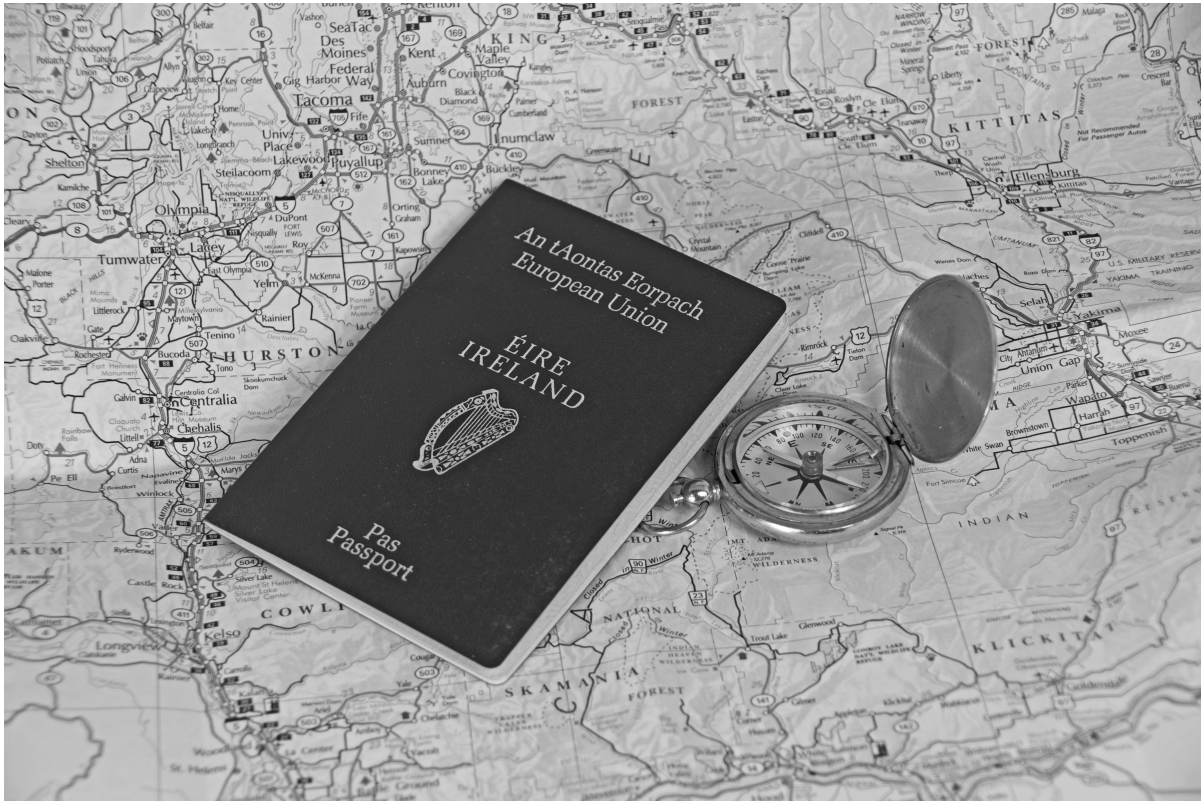


Text One

Passport Out of Here

adapted from an article by Marian Keyes

In this passage, the writer, who is an Irish citizen living in London, describes a time when she lost her passport.



Many years ago I was living in London and about to visit New York for the first time – my sister had moved there four months previously, and I was going to spend Christmas with her. Three nights before departure I began to pack and, when I looked in my ‘official things’ drawer for my passport, there it was – gone! Except it couldn’t be. It had sat in that drawer since I’d last needed it, on a trip to Greece the previous summer. I rummaged through bills and stuff expecting it to appear and, when it didn’t, I took the entire contents out and systematically went through each item one by one – nothing. My mouth went a little dry, my heart-rate increased but I told myself that it was here, I just couldn’t see it – hadn’t my mother always told me that I couldn’t find the water in the river?

But unless it had become invisible, it simply Was Not There. With sweaty hands I began to tear my room apart, going through every pocket of every item of clothing in my wardrobe, looking in old rucksacks and handbags, pulling books out of my bookcase, but although I stumbled across a handful of sandy foreign currency and half a bag of inexplicably abandoned sweets (still edible, quite nice actually), there was no passport. Then I launched an attack on the rest of the flat. Late into the night I finally had to admit the inadmissible: my passport wasn’t here. At this stage I was almost whimpering with terror; although my ticket to New York had put a huge dent in my meagre finances, it was non-changeable and non-refundable. If I hadn’t a passport in two days’ time I wouldn’t be going.

I went to bed in my bomb-site bedroom but I barely slept and got up again at about five a.m., whirling through the silent flat, looking behind boxes of breakfast cereals, inside video cases and when I arrived at work I was a hollow-eyed manic wreck, with the taste of panic in my mouth.

I spilled the terrible story to my boss Charlotte and she calmly advised me to apply for a new passport. 25

'But it takes weeks to get a passport and I leave in two days' time!' I had to try hard not to screech.

'Ring the Irish Embassy, tell them it's an emergency and send a courier for an application form.' 30

Within an hour, the application form was on my desk and Charlotte helped me read through the requirements because I was so frenzied the letters kept dancing in front of my eyes. First I needed a photo so she combed my hair and dispatched me to a nearby photo booth. (The photo is still in my passport, I'm a pretty shade of pistachio green.) Charlotte told me I could catch up on work later and pushed me out the door, shouting, 'Go, go, go!' like I was a man parachuting into enemy territory. 35

Then, gasping for breath, I was running through the streets of London, counting the numbers on the mansions, looking for the Irish Embassy. I found it and panted up the steps to the fancy front door, then back down again with a flea in my ear – the passport office was round the side and in the basement. Down the rickety spiral staircase I went, burst through the door – and suddenly I was no longer in a smart area of London but in a sub-post-office in Athlone, back in Ireland. 40

It was a tiny little place, with four rows of plastic chairs cowering beneath merciless strip lighting and a serving counter with three glass hatches. I grabbed a ticket: number 792. When was my turn? I looked around for the number display and there, in hellish red digital, was the next number in line. It read 23. My heart almost leapt out of my chest with panic. I'd be here forever! But no one was in sight, either in the waiting area or behind the counter ... 45

Then from some hidden back room, a plumpish young man appeared, came up to one of the hatches, looked at me and declared, 'Next!' 50

I looked in confusion at my ticket.

'Next,' he repeated.

'But ...' I flapped my little piece of paper.

'Oh, we don't bother with that.'

Fair enough. Up I stepped and blurted out the tragic tale of the missing passport, the non-refundable, non-changeable ticket, the lonely sister sitting out her first Christmas in New York and he listened, leaning easily on his elbow, nodding in sympathy. 55

'Right,' he sighed. 'We'd better organise you a new passport.'

Under the glass hatch I slid in my thick bundle of documentation – the application form, photos, birth certificate (which bizarrely I had a copy of at my office) and photocopies of my plane tickets which Charlotte had suggested I bring in case they needed to be convinced of the urgency of my case. 60

Text Two

How to Find Your Missing Keys and Stop Losing Other Things

adapted from an article in *The New York Times* by Christopher Mele

In this passage, the writer offers advice about how to find lost items.



When trying to find a lost item, such as your keys or wallet, don't waste time looking in places you already know the missing object is not, experts said.

You were sure you left the keys right there on the counter, and now they are nowhere to be found.

Where could they be?

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Misplacing objects is an everyday occurrence, but finding them can be like going on a treasure hunt without a map.

Here are some recommendations from experts to help you recover what is lost. (Consider printing this out and putting it someplace you can easily find it.)

Stay calm and search on

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One of the biggest mistakes people make is becoming panicked or angry, which leads to frantic, unfocused searching, said Michael Solomon, who wrote the book *How to Find Lost Objects*. 'There are no missing objects. Only unsystematic searchers.'

Look for the item where it's supposed to be. Sometimes objects undergo 'domestic drift' in which they were left wherever they were last used, Mr. Solomon said.

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'Objects are apt to wander,' he wrote in his book. 'I have found, though, that they tend to travel no more than 18 inches from their original location.'

Be disciplined in your search

A common trap is forgetting where you have already searched, Corbin Cunningham, a PhD student at John Hopkins University in Baltimore, USA, said in an email: 'Go from one room to another, and only move on if you think you have searched everywhere in that room,' he wrote. 20

'Don't go round in circles,' Mr. Solomon wrote in his book. 'No matter how promising a site – if the object wasn't there the first time, it won't be there the second.'

Once you have thoroughly searched an area and ruled it out, don't waste time returning to it. 25

Focus on cluttered areas

'The most efficient way to find something is not to look where you don't need to look,' a researcher at the University of Aberdeen in Scotland, Anna Nowakowska, wrote in an email. 'For example, if you're looking for your keys, you should focus on the areas with the most clutter because if they were somewhere more obvious, you would have found them by now. Our results suggest people probably waste a great deal of time looking in locations that they already know don't contain the thing they are looking for.' 30

Retrace your steps

Irene Kan, a professor of psychology at Villanova University in Pennsylvania, USA, who specializes in memory and cognition, said in an email that the key to finding misplaced items is forming a mental image of what you were doing or feeling when you last saw the missing item. Try to recreate as rich an experience as possible. Think about the location, what you were doing, the time of day, who else was there, your mental state and any other details. Engaging in this process can help you recall details that might otherwise be inaccessible, she said. 35 40

Use prevention strategies

One way to keep from losing things is to get in the habit of always putting them in the same place. Dr Devi, a doctor at Lenox Hill Hospital in Manhattan, New York, who specializes in memory disorders, said that when we lose things that are not part of our daily routine, such as important papers, it often happens because we are trying to keep them safe or private. 45

April Masini, who writes about relationships and behaviour for her website, AskApril.com, suggested taking preventative steps.

'Put a neon Post-it note on important papers and notebooks, a big, colorful key chain toggle on your keys and keep the ringer switched on, on your phone (which, ideally, is in a rainbow-colored case) so you can call it,' she wrote in an email. 'When you prepare for losing items – which we all do at all ages – you have a better chance of finding a marked-to-stand-out item, than one that camouflages itself into your décor.' 50

If you prefer more high-tech solutions, consider trackers which you attach to an item. An app helps you find its location. Other apps are available specifically to help you find your smartphone. 55

Remember, forgetting is normal

Dr Devi said as we get older, our memories can be challenged by the multitasking brought on by being at the peak of our professional careers and caring for children or parents.

60

She emphasized that forgetting is hard-wired into our brains as part of our evolution and that faulty memory is not a sign of lower intelligence.

Sources taken/adapted from:

Text One: 'Further Under the Duvet', Marian Keyes, Penguin 2017

Photograph: © Richard Goerg/Getty Images

Text Two: How to Find Your Missing Keys and Stop Losing Other Things by Christopher Mele

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